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Business Psychology: Posture

By **Chaz Wilke**, Content Writer

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Think for a moment of any great leader throughout history. Consider that image. Think about the soaring oratory and imposing sense that a titan among men presents. There are many factors in making a great leader, but all those worth following, without question, had fantastic posture.

With their chests thrust out and chins held toward the heavens, great leaders stand before their supporters, seemingly infallible. Their confidence can be overpowering as well as infectious.

But would any of that be conveyed by someone with her shoulders rolled forward? Would someone who barely lifts his head effectively convey a message of great importance to a massive crowd?

Not likely.

New York Times journalist Kate Murphy agrees in a piece on emerging social-science research. “Striking a commanding pose, whether you are in a sparkling gown or frayed jeans, [can change how you perceive yourself](#), which ultimately influences how you are perceived by others.” It is hard to refute the transformative nature of confidence. If you exude a presence of authority, it becomes hard for anyone else to deny your perspective.

There is little debate between the scientific and psychological communities. **Posture has a staggering effect on decisions.** It affects perception of self as well as an outward interpretation from others. A comprehensive study performed at Chicago's Northwestern University in 2001 and published in the Psychological Science journal says that posture "affected the implicit [activation of power, the taking of action, and abstraction.](#)" This means acting powerful may trick your brain into feeling powerful as a result.

Richard Petty, Ohio State University's professor of psychology and co-author on a study of posture, finds that our posture has powerful intrinsic transformative effects beyond external perception. "Most of us were taught that sitting up straight gives a good impression to other people," Petty says. "But it turns out that **our posture can also affect how we think about ourselves.** [If you sit up straight, you end up convincing yourself by the posture you're in.](#)



The Economist agrees: "Posture certainly matters. **Big is dominant and in species after species,** humans included, [postures that enhance the posturer's apparent size cause others to treat him as if he were more powerful.](#)"

Yet, this mountain of evidence may ultimately prove to be coincidental, not causal. Economist reader and commenter [going by the username of releaseTechnique argues](#), "I would tend to say that there is a feedback cycle between the emotive state and the physical position, so the arrow of causality cannot be traced univocally." In plain English, this is the classic chicken and egg scenario.

Since we are still in the early stages of truly unraveling this potential chicken and the egg scenario, we may still be years off from a true link to the causality of posture.

However, all flora and fauna on our planet operate under the consideration that bigger is better. Posture that creates a larger silhouette has been shown to manifest as command in every species on the planet.

Understanding the psychological ramifications of posture on business may still be in its infancy, but if we take a page from nature we see a clear correlation between posture and dominance.

So stand up straight. Keep your chin held high, and present yourself and what you have to say with confidence.

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